







EXHIBITION

HOW INDIA WAS BORN AGAIN

AN ONGOING EXHIBITION AT KOLKATA'S INDIAN MUSEUM REMINDS US THAT WE CAN DELIGHT IN OUR INDEPENDENCE

Though '75' is surely an important milestone, it is sometimes difficult for celebrations to feel original for the 75th time. Being held at Kolkata's Indian Museum until September 18, DAG's *March to Freedom: Reflections on India's Independence* does something unique—using the 75th anniversary of our Independence as both occasion and cause, it reinterprets the oft-repeated story of our freedom struggle, while also reimagining the cost and meaning of our much-prized 'Independence'. Curated by Mrinalini Venkateswaran, the exhibition borrows from the DAG collection not just its masterpieces, but also a stunning collection of photographs, prints and posters that it forces you to think of as 'art'.

Ditching the predictability of chronology, *March to Freedom* is divided into eight themes, inviting viewers to roam rather than follow some regular, pre-ordained path. Seeing how the exhibits are laid out, however, it is perhaps inevitable that one starts by being captivated (and also irked) by the British gaze. Painted in 1796, Thomas Daniell's 'The Western Entrance of Shere Shah's Fort, Delhi' is, of course, pretty to the point of being enchanting, but like in so many British depictions of Indian landscapes, Indians are conspicuously missing. The omission, it is clear, had more to do with ethics than aesthetics: If their art is anything to go by, the Brits were colonising land, not a people.

In 1794, when artists like Henry Singleton did portray Indians, they left us with works like 'Scarcity in India'—a somewhat ridiculous painting of two white men showing a thinclad Indian woman a mirror. Looking at 'The Imperial Durbar' a little while later, we again think of fashion. Sitting atop an elephant, Vicereine Mary Curzon wore a special Indian-embroidered dress, patterned on peacock feathers. In material terms, *March...* makes us tangibly see how India's lack resulted, in part, from British plenty.

DAG and Venkateswaran employ several devices to make this exhibition interactive, but their trick of using each description card to ask questions can seem both provocative and patronising. The label besides a 1940 photograph of Delhi's Secretariat buildings reads, "To create these spaces, several older villages and settlements were cleared, and their residents relocated. How do